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Voters casting ballots in 3 Los Angeles-area Assembly races

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SACRAMENTO, Calif. (AP) — Los Angeles-area residents were voting Tuesday on new representatives in the state Assembly after three lawmakers resigned last year.

Two of the races involve replacements for former Democratic Assemblymen Raul Bocanegra and Matt Dababneh. Both men resigned amid sexual misconduct accusations that they deny.

Voters will also choose a replacement for former Assemblyman Sebastian Ridley-Thomas after the Democrat quit while citing health problems.

If no one receives more than 50 percent of the vote, the top two vote-getters in each race will advance to a June runoff.

Polls close at 8 p.m.

Nearly 800,000 people are registered to vote in the three districts and Democrats outnumber Republicans in all three. Political operatives working for some of the candidates said they expect turnout to be around 9 percent.

The 45th District in the southwest San Fernando Valley has lacked representation in the Assembly since Jan. 1, when Dababneh resigned.

A lobbyist said he pushed her into a bathroom during a social event in Las Vegas and masturbated in front of her, which he denies.

Jesse Gabriel, a constitutional rights attorney, and Tricia Robbins Kasson, a Los Angeles City Council aide, are the leading fundraisers in the race to replace him.

Democrats Ankur Patel, Daniel Brin, Jeff Bornstein and Ray Bishop are also running. Dennis Zine, a no-party-preference candidate, will appear on the ballot but has announced he isn't campaigning.

The only Republican running in the district is 18-year-old Justin Clark, a college student who works part-time in an ice cream shop.

Bocanegra resigned his seat in the 39th District after multiple women accused him of unwanted groping and kissing. He has denied committing any crimes against the women.

His district, which encompasses the northeast area of the San Fernando Valley, has lacked representation since November.

Luz Rivas, a nonprofit founder and engineer, and Antonio Sanchez, a workforce development director, have raised the most money in their bids to replace Bocanegra.

Former Assemblywoman Patty Lopez is also running for the seat, along with three other Democrats — Bonnie Corwin, Yolanda Anguiano and Patrea Patrick. Ricardo Benitez is the only Republican in the race.

Residents of the 54th District, which includes the University of California, Los Angeles campus and Culver City, are also heading to the polls.

Tepring Piquado, a neuroscientist, and Sydney Kamlager, a Los Angeles Community College District trustee, are the leading fundraisers in the race to replace Ridley-Thomas. Republican Glen Ratcliff and Democrat Grayson Pangilinan are also running for the seat.

The elections are estimated to cost $1.6 million, according to Los Angeles County, which includes all three districts, except for a tiny sliver of the 45th District in Ventura County.

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